

SOME SEE **A BEACON OF HOPE,** OTHERS A SMOKE SCREEN

Unless the **issues with the WFI** are dealt with, any results at the Paris Olympics will only be papering over the underlying chaos.

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Indian wrestling had a disappointing season in 2023 and is looking to bounce back in the Olympic year. The sport had hoped to capitalise on the two medals won in Tokyo—a silver for Ravi Dahiya and a bronze for Bajrang Punia—but the preparations for the Paris Games have been far from ideal. Although there were some excellent performances on the mat last season, most of the news was unfortunately dominated by off-field controversies.

A significant undercurrent of athlete protests permeated the wrestling landscape throughout 2023. Esteemed wrestlers like four-time World medallist Bajrang, two-time World medallist Vinesh Phogat, and the sole Indian women's wrestling Olympic medallist Sakshi Malik took to the streets, levelling serious allegations of sexual misconduct against the then Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh.

The Ministry of Sports eventually suspended the federation, and despite a subsequent re-election in December, another ban followed shortly, leaving the sport in limbo.

The suspension of the federation has cast a shadow over Indian wrestling, halting national championships and disrupting the crucial talent pipeline. While athletes are still being sent for international competition, this is being done based on their performance in past years. The hope for the 2024 season hinges on the resumption of national sporting activities.

Despite the chaos in the Indian administration, Indian wrestlers have managed to achieve great results. Although there was no gold medal at the Asian Games in Hangzhou, unlike the 2018 edition in Indonesia, where Bajrang and Vinesh both finished on top of the podium, India had more success in the age group events compared to recent years. In August last year, India won four gold medals at the Junior World Championships. Antim Panghal, who became the first Indian woman to take gold at the Junior Worlds in the previous year,

replicated her achievement in Amman, Jordan. At the U-23 World Championships that followed in October, Reetika Hooda became the first Indian woman to claim gold, winning the 76kg title.

Antim was not content with just performing well at the junior level. At the senior world championship held later that year, she won a bronze medal on her debut. At only 19, she became the youngest Indian woman and the second-youngest overall to win a medal at the World Championships. Antim could have potentially competed for the gold medal in Belgrade, as she was leading 4-3 before her opponent Vanesa Kaladzinskaya scored off an exposure with the final move of the match. Antim was devastated by the result, but the bronze medal not only secured an Olympic quota for India but also established her as one of the most promising young wrestlers in the country.

Antim's last-second turn of fortune could potentially cost her more than just a world medal of a brighter colour. While a world medallist in any other weight